

BFC FAB Meeting 12/02/26

Microsoft Teams

Meeting start time: 17.55

Meeting end time: 20.12

1. Attendees

Name	Role	Representation
Jon Flatman	CEO, Barnsley FC	Club staff
John Bird	Head of Ticketing and Fan Engagement	Club staff
Paul Gallagher	FAB Member	Supporter representative
Steve Brain	FAB Chair / FAB Member	Supporter representative
Martin Wilson	FAB Member	Supporter representative
Claire Calton	FAB Member	Supporter representative

Apologies

Dominic Wood, Phil Hall, Robin Harris,

Agenda

1. Previous Minutes and Actions.
2. Season Tickets.
3. Football Governance Bill
4. Road Closures, Anti Terrorism.
5. FAB Re-set:
 - Comms
 - Social Media Presence
 - Fans' Questions
 - FAB Vacancies

6. Weston Park Raffle.
7. In ground Commentary.
8. AOB
9. Next Meeting.

1. Minutes of the meeting

Previous Minutes agreed and published on Club Website with no objections raised.

SB advised that the meeting was not quorate but that the meeting would proceed with minutes taken on a discussion basis only.

2. Season Tickets (JF)

Areas covered: renewal strategy, pricing pressure, incentives, revenue modelling and supporter expectations.

Rising costs and financial background

- JF outlined significant cost pressures:
 - National Insurance increases.
 - Minimum wage increases affecting casual staff.
 - Rising utilities and product costs.
 - Player wages increasing by on average around 13 percent year on year within the season across non promoted or related League 1 clubs.
 - Season ticket income reportedly around £1.5m net.
 - VAT removes 20% of any increase.
- JF emphasised the importance of season ticket revenue in sustaining the club and supporting squad competitiveness.

Attendance obstacles

- Fewer Saturday games.
- Increased midweek fixtures.

- Weather.
- Televised matches affecting walk up numbers.
- Importance of on pitch performance to attendees
- Examples of low attendance, such as the recent Tuesday match v Northampton.

Price increases

- JF indicated initial modelling of an increase was underway but subject to board approval.
- Club is undertaking L1 comparisons especially those who have released 26/27 prices.
- CC referenced seeing data suggesting Barnsley were already among the lowest priced.

Alternative ticketing options

Multiple ideas were raised by FAB members, with JF welcoming innovation:

a) Attendance incentive

- PG proposed a 100 percent attendance reward (rebate, voucher or similar), stressing that incentives should reward attendance rather than penalise absences.

b) Flexi ticketing

- PG and others suggested the flexi ticket had not been priced attractively enough.
- JB confirmed previous sales levels and difficulties in pricing between:
 - Early bird season ticket
 - Matchday prices
 - A meaningful flexi price
- JF noted limited margin between matchday and season ticket pricing leaves little space for flexi products and that Season tickets should always be the lowest price.

c) Variable pricing / “hot ticket” models

- JF referenced examples used in US sports where pricing changes by block occupancy.
- Challenges with seat migration identified, citing difficulties policing people relocating to higher value seats.

d) Midweek incentives

- CC proposed low cost gestures like a free hot drink on very cold nights, especially for children.
- JF agreed in principle and asked the ticketing team to model the cost based on 50 to 75 percent uptake.

e) Youth incentives

- Discussion around rewards for children attending all matches.
- CC suggested prizes such as meeting a favourite player or attending a training session.
- JF supported the idea and stressed all prizes must be realistic to obtain and not limited to one or two winners.

f) Marketing and payment models

- PG raised subscription style framing.
- JB confirmed existing four, six and ten month finance options via V12 Finance.
- JF explained:
 - In house subscription models cause severe cash flow problems.
 - Finance house solutions avoid cash flow issues but include set up costs.
 - Marketing could position the ten month plan as “£X per month”.
 - Club must comply with financial regulatory constraints.

g) Transfer window discussion relevant to season ticket messaging

- Several questions later in the meeting touched on:
 - January window activity.
 - Need to invest transfer funds wisely.
 - Ensuring fans believe in the squad direction.

(Detailed notes appear later under FAB Re set / Fans’ Questions.)

Outcome:

- Extensive exploratory discussion.
- No decisions taken due to non quorum.
- General agreement that:

- Incentives will be explored.
- Flexi ticket pricing will be reviewed.
- Marketing and subscription framing will be strengthened.

Actions: See Action Log.

3. Football Governance Bill / FAB (JF)

JF gave a substantial, detailed briefing on the new Independent Football Regulator (IFR) legislation.

Discussion Detail:

Overview of regulatory framework

- The IFR Act introduces a mandatory licensing regime across all leagues from Premier League to National League.
- Licensing criteria include fan engagement, financial sustainability, ownership structures and risk management.
- Fan engagement is one of five statutory areas where clubs must demonstrate compliance.

FAB structure and requirements

- Fan representatives must be democratically elected or clearly justified representatives (eg. supporters groups).
- Clubs cannot handpick members without justification.
- Hybrid models (elected plus appointed for marginalised groups) are allowed.
- The regulator can request justification for every FAB member.
- FAB meetings, agendas, minutes and governance will form part of a club's licence evidence.
- JF stated Barnsley FC is already ahead of many clubs, having operated FAB meetings for a year.

Timeline

- First consultation complete.
- Final regulatory framework expected in March.
- FAB structure and elections may need to be reviewed after March.

Reporting and compliance

- IFR is expected to be “light touch” for well run clubs but intrusive for high risk clubs.
- FAB must demonstrate transparency but commercial confidentiality still applies.

Outcome:

- JF advised that FAB members should read the full 50 plus page consultation document.
- JF to provide the document.
- Further structural decisions deferred until the final March IFR publication.

Actions: See Action Log.

Risks / Concerns:

- Any FAB composition changes made now may have to be reversed post March.
- Need to ensure accessibility of documents for visually impaired members.

4. Road Closures and Anti Terrorism (JF)

Context:

Anti terrorism threat level for sports grounds remains “substantial”. National guidance emphasises risks from vehicle attacks.

Discussion Detail:

- South Yorkshire Police have written to Barnsley Council requesting a rapid review of road closures around Oakwell.
- Desktop assessment suggests an extension to closures beyond Grove Street, including the three roads up the hill.
- JF stated the club is pushing back, seeking evidence of risks considered before changes are imposed.
- Any changes would affect vehicle access only.
- Residents also impacted.
- FAB minutes must word the issue carefully to avoid premature conclusions.

Outcome:

- Club to continue discussions with police, council and traffic management company.
- FAB to await further information.

Actions: See Action Log.

Risks / Concerns:

- Supporter disruption.
- Resident impact.
- Potential for misinterpretation if communicated poorly.
- Additional matchday costs to the club

5. FAB Re-set (PG / All)

Sub items: Comms, Minutes, Social Media, Fans' Questions, FAB Vacancies

(a) Comms and Minutes

- All recognised the problems the Group has had with minutes and minutes approval since FAB inception; creating a poor impression for those fans keen to see quick and meaningful communication. The use of co-pilot will help improve this area.

(b) Social Media Presence

- Not substantively discussed beyond general concern about communication reach.

(c) Fans' Questions

The meeting noted a very large volume of supporter questions submitted via PG. Due to time constraints and the long discussion on the regulator, JF cautioned against deferring everything to writing, as this may be perceived as avoidance and to ensure two way communication. JF was happy to answer all questions verbally and pick up additional items in writing.

The group recognised the importance of this and agreed to address as many questions as possible in the remaining time available in the meeting. Any questions not covered will be submitted to the Club in writing by PG/SB. The Club will respond asap.

Below are the **questions discussed verbally** during the meeting:

Topics Discussed Verbally

Fan Forum recording not published

- JF advised that there had been technical difficulties on the night with some footage being corrupted. This related to around 20 minutes prior to the interval.
- Independent journalists and FAB members were present so the content is already public.
- Club will publish remaining footage but accepted criticism unavoidable.

January transfer window

- JF provided a detailed summary:
 - Approximately 20 transactions.
 - Defensive reinforcement was a priority due to goals conceded.
 - New goalkeeper brought in early.
 - Experienced centre half signed as free agent to avoid deadline day dependency and to ensure early Jan arrival.
 - Striker succession planning explained.
 - DKD sale: Jon emphasised the club must show a pathway for players upon recruitment and when the right price is on offer, the club will consider these seriously. Uniqueness of the late offer from Wrexham and the opportunity for use of funds in a 'better buyers market' in the summer.
 - Scott Banks (loan) has been a valuable addition and Charlie Lennon (permanent) has high potential for the future.
 - Loan and permanent markets considered at all times.
 - Importance of the balance between young inexperienced but talented younger 'asset' players and of older more experienced players.
 - Difficult historic recruitment window of January due to being in season and always subject to change. eg Jacob Brown was diverted to Portsmouth on the final day of window.

- Full and wider engagement of more people internally within the recruitment process.
- Build upon the permanent recruitment of young talent BFC has in the building and grow that as a focus each window.
- Leo Farrell as an example of an academy youngster who may well benefit from an opportunity.

DKD Transfer fee

- JF outlined that all transfer values and contingencies (additional payments) are undisclosed at all clubs in recent times. BFC is no different in that respect.
- JF stated value would be visible in accounts.
- JF challenged assumptions about FAB members valuations for a 28 year old League One player.

Fan Zone

- Club has paused progress due to Christmas fixture congestion and January transfer window workload.
- To resume exploration of alternatives shortly.
- Possibility that improving concourses may offer better return than a small scale Fan Zone but all options will be considered.
- Licence restrictions limit non matchday usage which reduce viability of a larger fan zone.

Electronic advertising boards

- JF confirmed rental was c. £80k to £90k per year, purchase over £350k plus software and operating.
- No commercial justification at present due to low broadcast audience in League One.
- Would consider if a major sponsor required them as additional investment would offset with revenue.

Weekly lottery publication

- Commitment given to publish weekly where possible.
- Staff absences can delay posting but draws always occur.
- JB asked to handle supporter queries directly.

Club shop / Fanatics

- JF believes deal financially protects the club due to minimum guarantee set as previous profit level when in house.
- First two years were difficult operationally, but this year has been improved by all parties.
- Six monthly review upcoming; JF will share detail afterwards.

Coat hangers in West Stand toilets

- Already raised by JB and logged on maintenance system.
- Awaiting action.

Topics not discussed verbally but acknowledged for written response

PG/SB will submit the following fans' questions under the headings:

- Ownership and strategic direction
- Financial sustainability
- Academy
- Squad investment
- Ownership calls
- Governance and transparency
- Board expertise
- Consortium structure
- Managerial support
- Ticket release timing
- Relegation risk
- West Stand atmosphere and safe standing
- Catering standards
- Stewarding
- Away stand usage for home fans
- Disabled pricing
- All remaining retail, lottery, ticketing and stadium operation questions

The Club will provide a written response.

FAB Vacancies

- PG had circulated an advert for new members (three positions vacant).
- JF advised delaying any recruitment until after March, once IFR regulations confirm FAB structural requirements.
- SB and PG agreed.

Actions: See Action Log.

6. Weston Park Raffle (PH)

- On behalf of PH, SB noted the question from PH about whether the £400 charity donation had been transferred to Weston Park.
- JB explained the the funds were passed to the Finance Department the following morning after the event.
- Darren (club staff) liaising with Finance on transfer.

NB: post meeting update is that we are awaiting a date from Weston Park for the collection of monies and the cheque presentation

Outcome:

- John Bird to check with Finance in the morning.

Actions: See Action Log.

In Ground Commentary (PH)

- Issues were reported with quality during Bolton and Lincoln matches.
- New lead connectors and cables purchased by Phil to improve sound quality.
- JB confirmed equipment changes should improve reliability.
- Wider issues with volunteer commentators acknowledged.
- MW suggested creating student commentary internships to develop new talent.
- JF explained challenges with managing placements but welcomed the idea in principle.

Outcome:

- Improvements underway through hardware upgrades.
- Longer term review of media output planned for summer.

Actions: See Action Log.

7. Next Meeting

- No date set.
- Agreement to schedule after regulatory guidance expected in March.

8. Action Log

Ref	Action	Owner	Due date	Status
1	Model cost of providing free hot drinks for midweek fixtures at varying uptake rates	JB	Unconfirmed	New
2	Review flexi ticket pricing and positioning	JB / Ticketing Team	Before season ticket launch	In progress
3	Expand modelling of season ticket incentives, including 100 percent attendance reward	JF	Unconfirmed	New
4	Provide IFR consultation document to FAB once file sharing issue resolved	JF / JB	ASAP	New
5	Confirm accessibility of IFR documents for visually impaired users	JF / JB	Unconfirmed	New
6	Continue engagement with police and council regarding proposed road closure changes	JF	Ongoing	In progress

7	Send fan questions to Club for written replies	SB /PG	Immediate	New
8	Finance to confirm transfer of Weston Park raffle funds	JB	Next working day	New
9	Maintain weekly publication of lottery numbers and improve consistency	JB	Ongoing	In progress
10	Check status of coat hanger installation in toilet cubicles	JB	Unconfirmed	In progress
11	Defer FAB vacancy recruitment until post March IFR framework	FAB / Club	March	New
12	Summer review of media output and in ground commentary structure	Club Media Team	Summer 2026	Scheduled